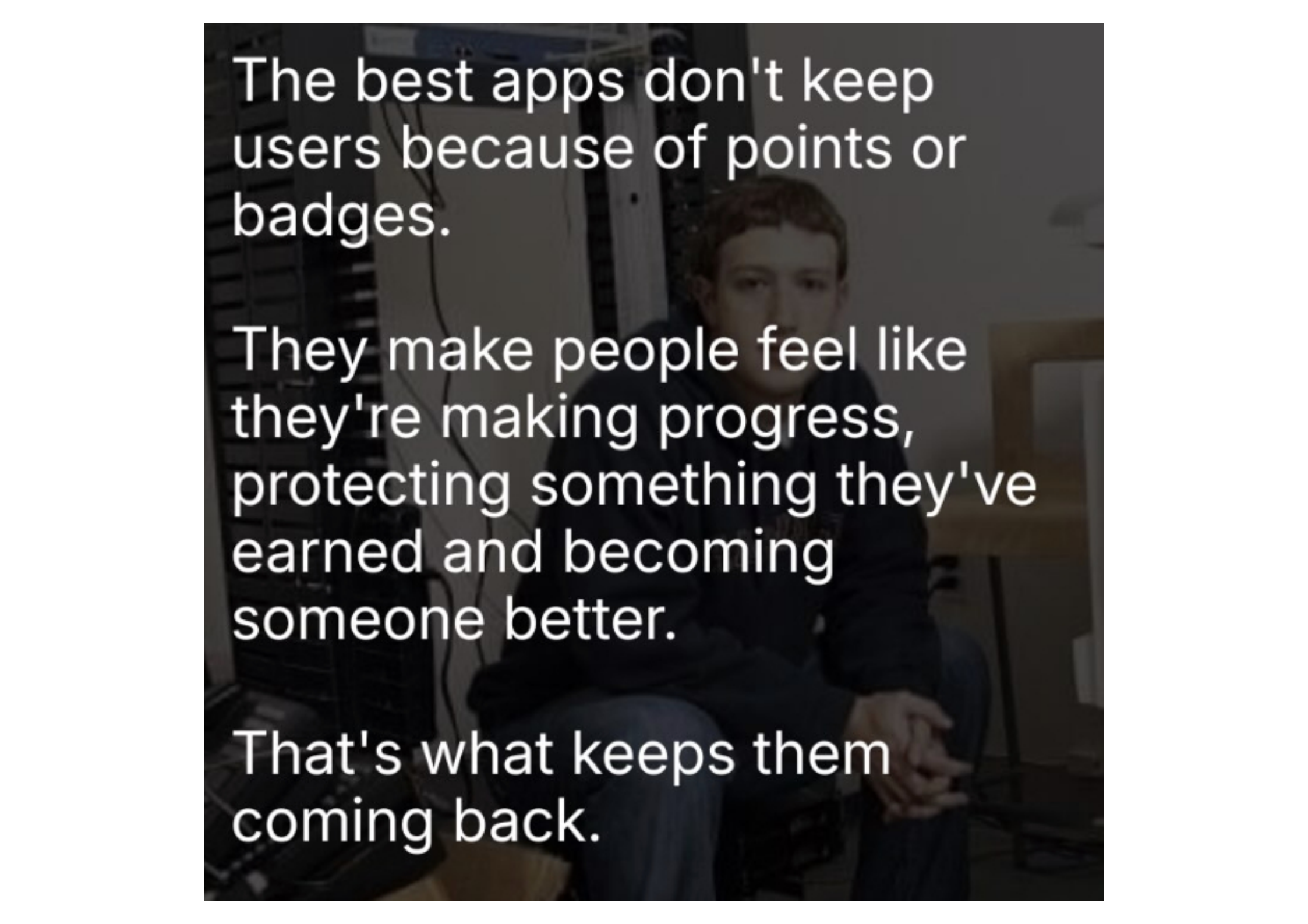
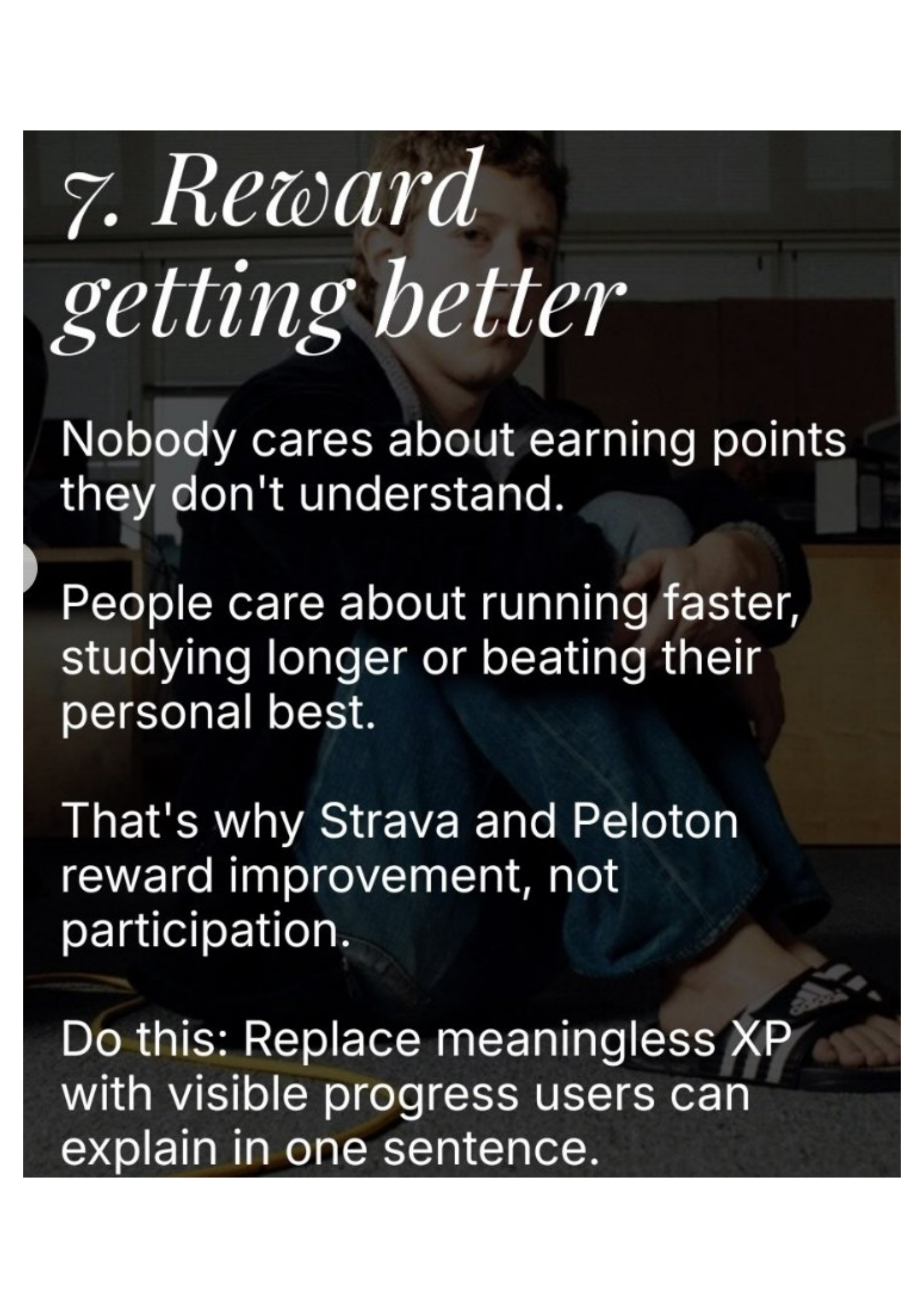


A photograph of Mark Zuckerberg sitting in a room with server racks in the background. He is wearing a dark hoodie and looking directly at the camera. The image is dimly lit, with the server racks providing some background detail.

The best apps don't keep
users because of points or
badges.

They make people feel like
they're making progress,
protecting something they've
earned and becoming
someone better.

That's what keeps them
coming back.

A person with curly hair is sitting on the floor, looking down. They are wearing a dark jacket and blue jeans. The background is a blurred indoor setting. The text is overlaid on the image in a white, serif font.

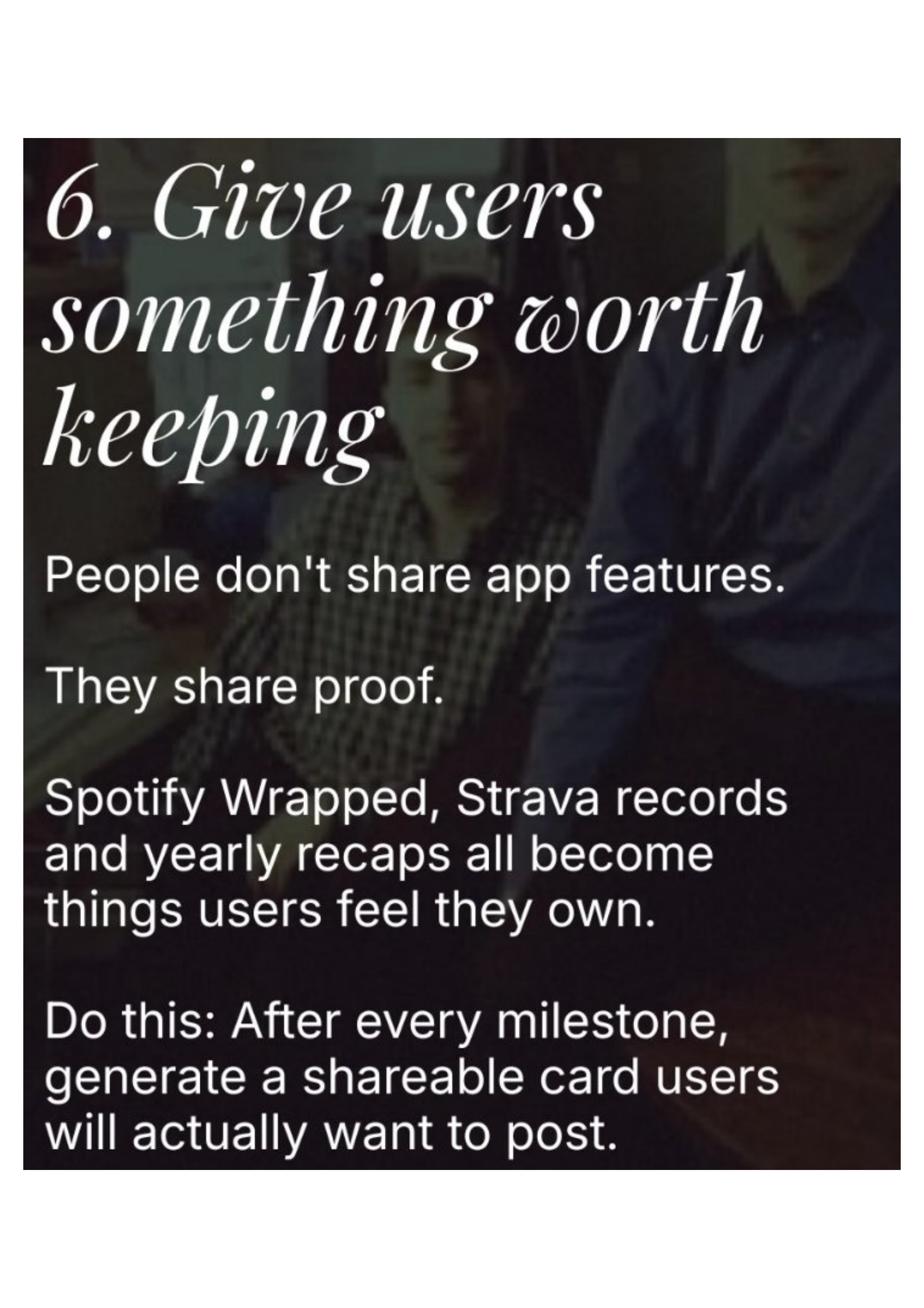
7. Reward getting better

Nobody cares about earning points
they don't understand.

People care about running faster,
studying longer or beating their
personal best.

That's why Strava and Peloton
reward improvement, not
participation.

Do this: Replace meaningless XP
with visible progress users can
explain in one sentence.

A background image showing three people (two men and one woman) smiling and looking towards the camera. The image is dark and slightly blurred, serving as a backdrop for the text.

6. Give users something worth keeping

People don't share app features.

They share proof.

Spotify Wrapped, Strava records and yearly recaps all become things users feel they own.

Do this: After every milestone, generate a shareable card users will actually want to post.

5. Reward the comeback

Every user will eventually miss a day.

The best apps don't punish them immediately.

They make returning feel like a win.

Do this: Add streak freezes, comeback bonuses or "complete one task today to restore your streak"

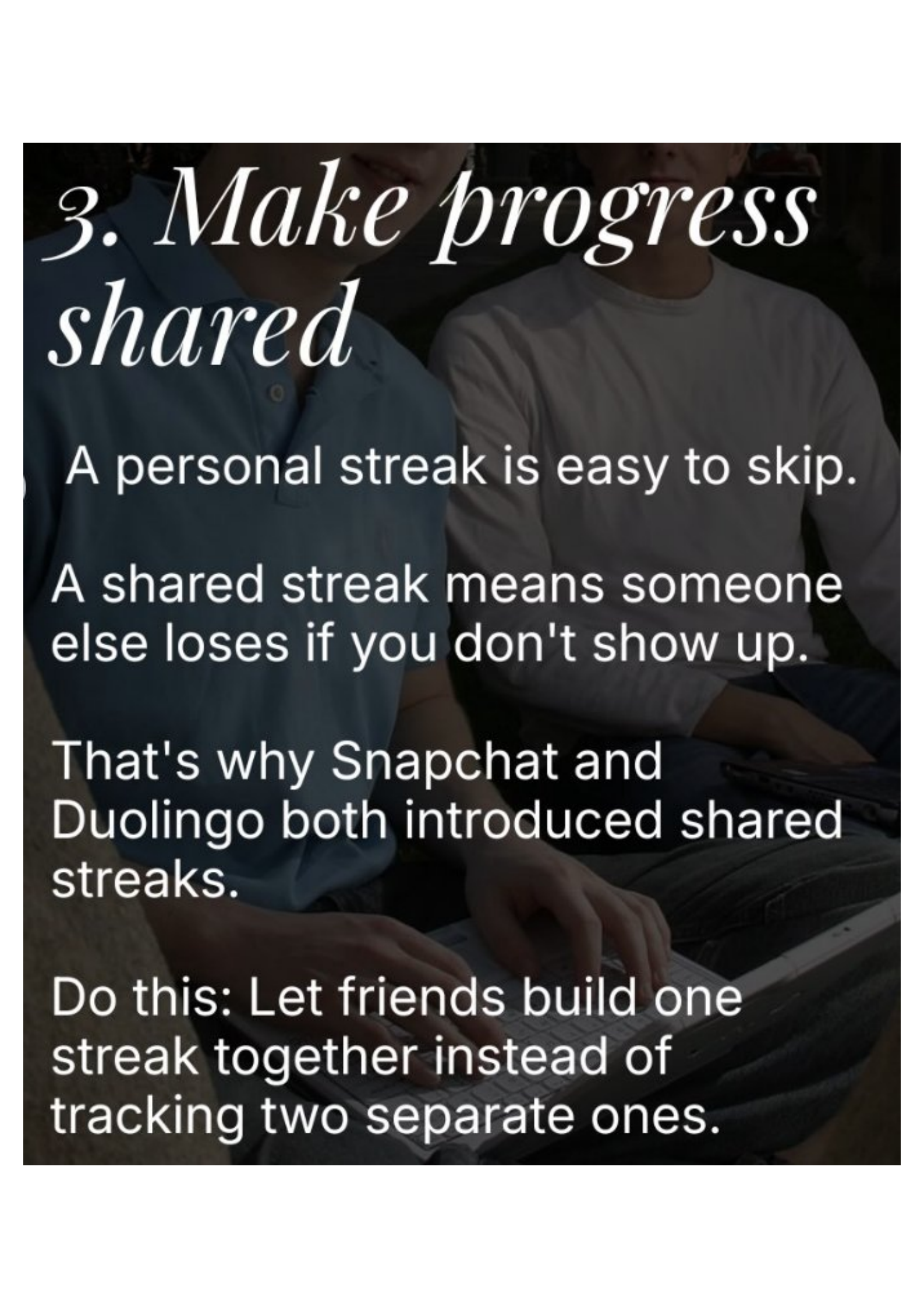
4. Always leave one thing unfinished

Apple doesn't overwhelm users with ten metrics.

It shows three rings and leaves one incomplete until the day is finished.

That unfinished progress keeps pulling people back.

Do this: Pick ONE daily metric and always show users exactly how close they are to finishing it.

A background image showing two people, a man and a woman, sitting at a desk and working on a laptop. The man is on the left, wearing a blue shirt, and the woman is on the right, wearing a white shirt. They are both looking at the laptop screen. The image is dimmed to serve as a background for the text.

3. Make progress shared

A personal streak is easy to skip.

A shared streak means someone else loses if you don't show up.

That's why Snapchat and Duolingo both introduced shared streaks.

Do this: Let friends build one streak together instead of tracking two separate ones.

2. Make winning feel possible

● Nobody opens an app to see they're ranked #82,491.

Duolingo places users into small groups of around 30 people with similar activity so everyone feels like they have a chance.

Do this: Create weekly leagues of 20-30 users instead of one global leaderboard.

1. Never show a new user a zero

Don't let someone register and immediately see 0 points, a 0-day streak and an empty achievement page.

Give them their first reward for creating an account, finishing onboarding or setting their first goal.

Do this: Award 10 points at signup, start their progress bar at 10%, or unlock a "Getting Started" badge before they reach the home screen.